job to, as well as being able to see the print queue. You can also cancel any print jobs by going to ***Start > Settings > Printers***.

Installing additional drivers

If you're sharing your printer, you'll want users running any version of Windows to be able to use it. If you're running Windows 2000 or XP, it is advisable to install additional drivers, so that others don't have to look for drivers before using your printer. To do this, go to ***Start > Control Panel > Printers***. Right-click the printer icon and choose Properties. In the Sharing tab, click the 'Additional Drivers...' button. Follow the on-screen instructions to install the drivers. Now all users will be able to install the drivers by just double-clicking the printer name.

Disabling printer announcements

If you are sharing a printer on a Windows 2000/NT machine, it will announce to the other print servers on the network that it has a printer available, every 10 minutes. These announcements can cause excessive network traffic. To disable them, go to ***Start > Run*** and type in '***regedit***' to open up the registry editor. Navigate to ***HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE\SYSTEM\CurrentControlSet\Control\Print***, and add a new value with the name as DisableServerThread, and the type as '***REG_DWORD***'. Enter a value of 1. This disables the announcements, but also means that the printer will not be visible when one is browsing the network. It can still be accessed by entering the name in manually. To turn the announcements back on, change the value in the registry back to 0.

Instead of disabling the announcements altogether, you can change the time interval between announcements. Simply add a new key named ServerThreadTimeout at the same location as above. Enter the value for this key in milliseconds. For example, if you want to extend the interval to one hour, enter the value '***3600000***'.

Restricting printer times

You can set a schedule for when a printer will be available for use. In Windows 2000 and XP, go to ***Start > Control Panel > Printers***, right-click on the printer, and choose Properties. On the Advanced tab, there are two choices near the top: 'Always available' and 'Available From...', where you can set the time during which print jobs can be printed. Users can still submit jobs any time they want, but the jobs will not be printed except during the times set for the printer as available.

You can restrict the times when a printer will handle jobs

Command Line Control

You can use the Net Print command to control what print jobs are currently running on a computer. The syntax for the Net Print command is ***NET PRINT \\computername\sharename [\\computername]job_id[/HOLD|/RELEASE| /DELETE]***.

Here the vertical bars mean 'or', job_id is the identification number of the job and the optional fields are in square brackets. If you type in just the command without any options, it will display the current print jobs. If you don't remember the share name of the printer, type in '***NET VIEW \\computername***' to list all the shared resources.

Miscellaneous Tips

Printing shortcuts

You don't have to launch an application and then go to ***File > Print*** in order to print a file. Go to ***Start > Settings > Printers***. Select the printer of your choice. Right-click the selected printer, and select 'Create Shortcut'. Windows will tell you that it can't create the shortcut here, and will ask you if you want it on your desktop. Click Yes. Then, whenever you want to print in a hurry, just highlight the file you want to print, and drag it onto the printer shortcut on your desktop.

You can also add a shortcut to the Send To menu of the Explorer for immediate printing. To do this, open ***C:\Windows\SendTo***, and create a shortcut there for your printer. Next time you want to print a file, simply right-click the file in the explorer window, and choose your printer from the Send To menu.

Economic printing

To save toner or ink, it's a good idea to keep your default print settings to Draft, or EconoMode—especially when you don't always need high quality prints. To do this, go to ***Control Panel > Printers***, and choose the printer properties by right-clicking the printer icon. You can later change the settings temporarily through the Print dialog of the application that you are printing from, as and when you need high quality prints.

Further, save paper by printing on both sides of the page. If your printer doesn't support two-sided printing, feed the paper manually, and flip it over to print on the other side. You can also use software such as FinePrint (***www.fineprint.com***) for double-sided prints. Do remember to set the page margins to the minimum value s upported. This will allow more matter to be printed on fewer pages.